

THE FIT FOUNDER'S BLUEPRINT

HOW TO DESIGN AND PRINT A PREMIUM SPORTS SUPPLEMENT LABEL



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Introduction

What This Book Is, What It Isn't, and What You'll Walk Away With



You have a formula, maybe a logo, and somewhere between \$5,000 and \$15,000 that you cannot afford to waste. You want to launch a supplement that looks like it belongs next to Ghost or CBUM on the shelf, not something that screams “I made this in my apartment.” But every time you try to move forward, you hit the same wall: print jargon you don’t understand, FDA rules that contradict each other depending on who you ask, and a gut feeling that one wrong decision will burn through your entire budget on a label you can’t use. That wall is why you’re here. This book tears it down.

What This Book Is

This is a step-by-step operating manual for designing, printing, and selling a premium sports supplement label. It covers everything from picking your first product to negotiating with printers to building a Shopify store that converts. Every chapter ends with specific action steps. Every recommendation includes real numbers: costs, margins, timelines, and benchmarks. If a chapter references a tool, it tells you the exact tool. If it references a process, it gives you the exact steps.

What This Book Is Not

This is not a formulation guide. It will not teach you biochemistry or how to design a pre-workout stack from scratch. It is not a generic “how to start a business” book padded with motivational filler. And it is not written for someone with a \$200,000 budget and a team of five. It is written for a founder with limited capital, no packaging experience, and zero tolerance for vague advice.

What You Will Have When You Finish



- A validated product decision backed by current market data and a phased manufacturing plan that matches your budget
- A defined buyer archetype and a positioning statement that governs every design and copy choice
- A locked-in brand identity: colors, typography, voice, and a three-sentence manifesto
- A label wireframe with correct visual hierarchy, benefit-first copy, and premium finish specifications

- A fully FDA-compliant Supplement Facts panel, vetted structure/function claims, and proper allergen declarations
- A print-ready file packaged for a commercial printer with zero revision rounds
- Three copy-paste email scripts for contacting printers and manufacturers like a veteran
- A library of photorealistic product mockups and a conversion-optimized Shopify store architecture ready to take orders

How to Use This Book

The 12 chapters are sequential. Each one builds on the decisions made in the chapter before it, so skipping ahead means missing context that affects your output. Read it cover to cover the first time. It takes about two hours. Then go back and work through the action steps chapter by chapter. Most founders complete the full process in four to six weeks alongside their regular work.

You do not need design software to start. You do not need a finished formula. You need a product idea, a rough budget, and the willingness to follow a process that has been tested against real production runs, real printers, and real FDA requirements.

Chapter 1 starts with the most important decision you will make: which product to manufacture first. **Turn the page.**

CHAPTER 1

Picking Your Product

Market Intelligence for First-Time Founders



The Market You're Stepping Into

The global sports nutrition market hit \$62.6 billion in 2025. It is projected to pass \$108 billion by 2034. Those are big numbers, but they aren't the ones that matter to you.

Here's the number that matters: performance nutrition, the segment that includes pre-workouts, creatine, hydration mixes, and nootropics, grew 22% in dollar sales over the 52 weeks ending November 2025, according to SPINS tracking data. The broader supplement category grows 6–7% annually. Performance nutrition is growing at three to four times that rate. You are not entering a dying market. You are entering one in the middle of a demand spike.

Two ingredients are leading the charge. Creatine monohydrate grew 77% in dollar value over that same period, with nearly half of all buyers making repeat purchases. Electrolyte and hydration products are the second-fastest movers, with 8% of U.S. consumers reporting regular consumption. Both of these categories also happen to be the easiest to manufacture and the most forgiving for a first-time founder. That's not a coincidence. It's your opening.

Which Product Should You Actually Make?

Not every supplement is a smart first product. Protein powder has the highest consumer awareness, but it also has the thinnest margins and the most ruthless competition. RTD (ready-to-drink) beverages require specialized co-packing equipment and enormous MOQs. Testosterone boosters carry significant regulatory scrutiny.

Below is a simplified ranking of the categories that make sense for someone with \$5k–15k in startup capital, scored across five factors: market demand, manufacturing simplicity, regulatory simplicity, gross margin potential, and brand storytelling fit.

Product	Demand	Complexity	Margin	Rating
Creatine Monohydrate (Powder)	Explosive	Low	65–80%	★★★★★
Electrolyte Stick Packs	Strong	Low–Med	70–85%	★★★★★

Product	Demand	Complexity	Margin	Rating
Pre-Workout Powder	Recovering	Medium	60–75%	★★★★
Nootropic / Focus Blend	Growing	Medium	70–85%	★★★★
Greens Powder	Strong	Medium	65–80%	★★★★
Protein Powder	Stable	Med–High	40–60%	★★★

The top pick is creatine monohydrate powder. It is a single-ingredient product, which



simplifies your Supplement Facts panel, your FDA compliance, and your manufacturing. Raw material cost is roughly \$8–15 per kilogram. A 60-serving tub (300g of creatine) costs about \$2.40–\$4.50 in raw ingredient. With manufacturing, packaging, labeling, and fulfillment, your all-in COGS lands between \$4–\$8 per unit.

Second pick: electrolyte hydration stick packs. COGS per stick runs \$0.15–\$0.40. Sell a 30-count box at \$24.99–\$34.99. Margins reach 70–85%. The format also lends itself to variety packs, limited editions, and subscription bundles, all of which increase average order value.

White-Label, Private-Label, or Custom Formula?

This isn't about which model is "better." It's about which model matches your phase.

With \$5k–15k, you don't have the budget to guess. Here's how the three options break down in plain terms.

Factor	White-Label	Private-Label	Custom
Time to market	2–4 weeks	4–8 weeks	12–16+ weeks
Minimum investment	\$1k–\$5k	\$3k–\$10k	\$20k–\$40k+
Typical MOQ	100–500 units	500–1,500 units	2,500–5,000 units
Formula ownership	None	Partial	Full IP
Differentiation	Low	Moderate	High
Long-term margin	Lower	Moderate	Highest at scale

The smart play is phased. Start with white-label to validate demand. Your first 500 units are a market research experiment, not a brand launch. If those 500 units sell through in 60–90 days, you have proof. Move to private-label, where you can modify the base formula (add a branded ingredient like Creapure-certified creatine, adjust the flavor). Once monthly revenue consistently exceeds \$10k–\$20k, invest in a custom formulation that you own as intellectual property.

Do not skip the validation phase. Roughly 42% of startups fail because there isn't sufficient demand for the product. A \$3,000 white-label test that sells out is infinitely more valuable than a \$25,000 custom formula sitting in your garage.

What It Actually Costs

Here's a concrete scenario. Let's call our founder Marcus. He's a personal trainer with 22k Instagram followers and \$8,000 saved. He wants to launch a creatine monohydrate powder under his own brand.

Marcus goes with a white-label approach. He orders 500 units of unflavored creatine monohydrate from a cGMP-certified contract manufacturer at \$4.50 per tub (\$2,250 total). He hires a designer for a premium label with spot UV on the logo (\$1,200). Label printing on BOPP film for 500 units costs \$350. A GS1 barcode license is \$250. Product photography and 3D mockup renders run \$500. His Shopify store setup (theme, domain, apps) costs \$300. He reserves \$2,000 for the first 30 days of Meta and TikTok ads.

Total out-of-pocket: \$6,850. That's within his \$8,000 budget and leaves a cash buffer. If he sells each tub at \$34.99 and moves all 500 units, gross revenue is \$17,495. After COGS, his gross profit is roughly \$12,000 before ad spend. That's enough to fund a private-label run at higher volume.

If Marcus had jumped straight to a custom formulation (flavored pre-workout, 2,500 units), his minimum investment would have been \$20,000–\$35,000 for R&D, raw-

materials, manufacturing, testing, and packaging. He would have burned through his entire budget with no market validation.

Vetting Your Contract Manufacturer

Your contract manufacturer (CM) determines your product quality, your legal exposure, and your ability to scale. Do not choose based on price alone. Here are the four non-negotiables.

cGMP certification is mandatory. Your CM must operate under Current Good Manufacturing Practices per 21 CFR Part 111. Ask for their most recent FDA inspection report (FDA Form 483). Verify there are no outstanding warning letters on the FDA's public database.

Every batch needs a Certificate of Analysis (COA). The COA should come from an independent, ISO 17025-accredited lab. It should verify identity, potency, purity, and the absence of heavy metals (arsenic, lead, cadmium, mercury) and microbial contaminants.

Ask about MOQ flexibility. Standard MOQs for powders are 2,500–5,000 units. But many CMs offer pilot runs of 500–1,000 units at a higher per-unit cost. That premium is worth paying during your validation phase.

Confirm labeling capabilities. Some CMs apply labels in-house. Others ship unlabeled “bright stock” for you to label through a separate co-packer. If their in-house labeling can't handle premium finishes (spot UV, foil stamping), plan to source labels from a dedicated print house. Chapter 4 covers this in detail.

What to do now:

- 1. Pick one product category.** Use the table in this chapter and score each option you're considering. If you're unsure, start with creatine monohydrate powder. It has the highest demand growth, lowest manufacturing complexity, and widest margin spread for a new founder.



2. **Set your budget ceiling and match it to a manufacturing model.** If you have under \$8k, go white-label (500 units). If you have \$8k–\$15k, go white-label first and reserve capital for a private-label reorder. Do not attempt custom formulation until you have validated demand and have \$20k+ available.
3. **Identify three contract manufacturers and request quotes.** Search for “cGMP sports supplement contract manufacturer” and request quotes from at least three CMs. Ask every one of them for their FDA 483, a sample COA, and per-unit pricing at 500-unit and 2,500-unit quantities. Chapter 10 has the exact email scripts for this.
4. **Register a GS1 Company Prefix for your UPC barcode.** Go to gs1us.org and purchase a company prefix. This is the only legitimate source of UPC barcodes in the United States. You will need this before your label can be printed. Cost: \$250 for the initial license.
5. **Do not design your label yet.** You need Chapters 2 through 4 first: your target buyer profile, your brand identity, and your premium finish specifications. The

Next: Chapter 2 — Defining Your Buyer: Audience Positioning in a Saturated Market

CHAPTER 2

Defining Your Buyer

Audience Positioning in a Saturated Market



“Everyone Who Lifts” Is Not a Customer

The fastest way to waste your \$5k–15k is to design a label for “anyone who works out.” That feels like a massive addressable market. In practice, it means your color palette is generic, your copy is vague, and your product blends into the 40,000+ supplement SKUs already fighting for attention.

Ghost charges \$44.99 per tub of pre-workout. They don’t sell to “fitness enthusiasts.” They sell to a specific person who identifies with pop culture, hype drops, and Instagram aesthetics. The buyer’s identity is doing the selling. The powder inside the tub is almost secondary.

Your label, your color choices, your typography, your copy, and your finish selections all flow downstream from a single decision: who is this for? Every chapter that follows depends on your answer here.

The Five Buyer Archetypes

Every profitable supplement brand maps to one of these five profiles. They overlap at the margins, but each carries distinct values, visual expectations, and price tolerance. Your job is to commit to one.

Archetype	Core Value	Pays Up To	Finds Brands On	Label Feels Like
Competitive Bodybuilder	Dose transparency, clinical proof, banned-substance testing	\$40–\$55	YouTube, forums, coach referrals	Clinical, clean. Transparent Labs.
Hybrid Athlete	Performance across training styles, recovery speed	\$35–\$50	Podcasts (Huberman), Instagram, gym culture	Bold, rugged. Momentous, Thorne.
Aesthetic Enthusiast	How the brand looks in their content and on their shelf	\$35–\$50	TikTok, IG Reels, influencer drops	Design-forward, hype. CBUM, Ryse.
Gamer / Cognitive	Focus, reaction time, sustained energy without jitters	\$30–\$45	Twitch, Discord, Reddit, YouTube	Dark, tech-inspired. CTRL, GFuel.

Archetype	Core Value	Pays Up To	Finds Brands On	Label Feels Like
Wellness Casual	Clean ingredients, simplicity, zero bro-culture	\$25–\$40	TikTok wellness, Pinterest, health blogs	Minimal, soft palette. AG1, Ritual.

Notice the price ranges overlap. A Competitive Bodybuilder and a Wellness Casual can both buy creatine monohydrate. But the label that attracts one actively repels the other. That tension is exactly why you must pick a lane.

How the Top Brands Picked a Lane

Ghost chose the Aesthetic Enthusiast who also identifies with pop culture. Licensed flavor collabs with Chips Ahoy and Sour Patch Kids. Transparent tubs. Loud typography. Everything about the label says “this is a lifestyle product, not a boring supplement.”

Momentous chose the Hybrid Athlete who trusts peer-reviewed science. Muted packaging, clean sans-serif type, a prominent NSF Certified for Sport badge. The label looks like it belongs in a sports medicine clinic. That’s the intent.

Raw Nutrition / CBUM chose the Aesthetic Enthusiast who idolizes classic bodybuilding. Metallic finishes, bold color blocking, Chris Bumstead’s personal brand woven into every SKU. Buyers aren’t purchasing a pre-workout. They’re purchasing membership in that world.

Ghost doesn’t chase the clinical crowd. Momentous doesn’t do candy flavor collabs. That discipline is why each of them commands \$40+ per unit. Pick one identity and commit.

Your Positioning Statement

You need one sentence that governs every decision from here forward. Use this formula:

We make [product] for [specific person] who wants [outcome] but is frustrated by [current alternative].

A concrete example: Say you're a personal trainer who coaches hybrid athletes. People who mix weightlifting with running, rucking, and functional fitness. Your positioning statement:

We make a clean electrolyte mix for hybrid athletes who want fast recovery across multiple training styles but are frustrated by pre-workouts loaded with artificial ingredients and unnecessary stimulants.

That sentence dictates everything. Your label should feel active and versatile, not body-building-specific. Your ingredient panel should be short and transparent. Your color palette should lean toward bold earth tones, not neon or gothic black. If your statement could apply to any product in any category, it's too vague. Rewrite it until it could only describe your brand.

Validate Your Audience for \$0 and 90 Minutes

Amazon 3-star reviews are your richest data source. Find the top three competing products in your category. Skip the 5-stars and the 1-stars. Three-star reviewers are specific: "tastes fine but the scoop is way too big for my shaker," or "works great but I wish it didn't have sucralose." Those complaints are your label messaging opportunities. Copy them word-for-word into a document.

Reddit threads reveal real buyer language. Search r/supplements, r/fitness, or r/crossfit for your product category. Find threads where people ask "what creatine do you use" and read the replies. Note which brands get praised, which get trashed, and the exact words people use. Those words belong on your label.

TikTok comments show purchase triggers. Search your category on TikTok. Find review or unboxing videos with 50k+ views and read the comments. You'll see patterns: "where do I buy this," "does this have artificial sweeteners," "the packaging looks so clean." Those patterns are what your label needs to communicate at first glance.

This process gives you something more useful than a survey: unfiltered language from buyers who don't know a brand is listening. It's the difference between writing "supports athletic performance" on your label and writing "so you're not gassed by round three." The second one sells. The first one gets ignored.

What to do now:

- 1. Pick one archetype from the table above.** Choose the one whose frustrations you can describe from personal experience. If you coach CrossFitters, pick the Hybrid Athlete. If you run a bodybuilding brand on Instagram, pick the Aesthetic Enthusiast. Go with what you know.
- 2. Write your positioning statement.** Use the formula: “We make [product] for [specific person] who wants [outcome] but is frustrated by [current alternative].” Don’t move to Chapter 3 until this sentence is on paper. It governs every design and copy decision from here.
- 3. Run the 90-minute validation process.** Read 15–20 Amazon 3-star reviews, scan Reddit threads, and pull TikTok comments for your product category. Copy the exact phrases buyers use into a single document. This becomes your raw copy bank for label text and ad creative.
- 4. Identify your buyer’s discovery channels.** Using the archetype table, write down the two or three platforms where your specific buyer discovers new brands. This determines where you’ll market (Chapter 12) and what formats your mockup images (Chapter 11) need to be built for.
- 5. Stress-test with one question.** “If I showed this label to my target buyer, would they instantly know it was made for them?” If the answer is no, your positioning is still too broad.

Next: Chapter 3 — Brand Aesthetics & Voice

CHAPTER 3

Brand Aesthetics & Voice

Designing an Identity That Commands a Premium



What Your Colors Say Before Your Copy Does

A customer scanning a supplement shelf makes a judgment about your brand in under two seconds, based almost entirely on color. Before they read your product name or your ingredient panel, they've already decided whether your tub belongs in their hand or stays on the shelf. Color in the supplement aisle is not decorative. It's a positioning signal.

Color Direction	What It Signals	Best For	Used By
Matte Black + Metallic Accents	Premium authority, exclusivity, seriousness	Pre-workout, testosterone support, high-ticket SKUs	CBUM Thavage, Gorilla Mind, Bucked Up
Clean White + Minimal Color	Clinical trust, transparency, science-first	Creatine, protein, health-focused formulas	Thorne, Transparent Labs, Momentous
Neon / Electric Brights	Energy, hype, youthful irreverence	Pre-workout, energy, gaming supplements	Ghost, GFuel, Ryse
Earth Tones / Muted Naturals	Clean-label, organic, wellness-oriented	Greens, adaptogens, plant-based protein	AG1, Ritual, Beam
Bold Red / Orange	Power, aggression, urgency	Pre-workout, mass gainers, strength formulas	BSN, MuscleTech, GAT Sport

Pick a primary color direction that matches your Chapter 2 archetype. Targeting the Aesthetic Enthusiast? Matte black with a metallic accent is proven. Targeting the Wellness Casual? Earth tones or clean white. Do not combine neon brights with a clinical white palette. Mixed signals kill premium perception.

Typography Rules for the Supplement Shelf

Premium supplement brands overwhelmingly use sans-serif display typefaces for product names. This is a readability decision, not a trend. Sans-serif fonts are legible at arm's length on a curved tub surface, which is how your product gets evaluated in retail and in a small product image on a phone screen.

Your brand needs two typefaces. A display font for the product name and hero callouts (bold, high-contrast, geometric or grotesque sans-serif like Montserrat, Bebas Neue, or Gilroy), and a body font for the Supplement Facts panel, legal text, and de-

scriptions (clean, highly legible, like Inter, Roboto, or Helvetica Neue). That's it. Two fonts maximum. Three or more fonts on a single label is one of the clearest signals of amateur design.

The test: if you can't read your product name from five feet away on a phone screen, your display type is too thin, too decorative, or too small. Bold weight, tight tracking, high contrast against the background. No exceptions.

Crafting a Brand Voice That Sells

Your brand voice is how you sound in writing: on the label, in ads, in emails, in social captions. It sits somewhere on a spectrum between clinical authority and hype culture. Most founders default to bland middle ground that sounds like a Wikipedia entry. That won't sell a \$40 tub.

Voice Position	Sounds Like	Label Copy Example	Brand Reference
Clinical / Scientific	Peer-reviewed, restrained, data-driven	"5g Creatine Monohydrate. Third-party tested for purity."	Thorne, Momentous, Transparent Labs
Coach / Authority	Confident, direct, no-nonsense instruction	"Recovery starts here. 5g clinical-dose creatine."	Jocko Fuel, Legion Athletics
Hype / Culture	Energetic, irreverent, community-driven	"LOAD UP. 5g of pure creatine to fuel the next PR."	Ghost, Ryse, Raw Nutrition
Wellness / Approachable	Warm, simple, inclusive, calming	"Creatine made simple. One scoop. Every day."	AG1, Beam, Ritual

All four examples describe the same product: 5g creatine monohydrate. The ingredient is identical. The voice changes who picks it up. Choose one column and stay in it. Your label copy, Instagram captions, product page, and email subject lines should all sound like they came from the same person.

Your Minimum Viable Brand Kit

Before you open a design file or brief a designer, lock down these five assets. Every professional designer and commercial printer expects them to exist.

1. Primary Logo. Vector format (.AI or .SVG), black and white versions, and a reversed (white-on-dark) version. If your logo only exists as a PNG from Canva, it is not print-ready.

2. Secondary Mark. A simplified icon or monogram for small applications: tub lid, scoop, social profile images, favicon. If your full logo doesn't read clearly at 0.5 inches wide, you need this.

3. Color Palette with Exact Values. Define your primary, secondary, and accent colors in three formats: HEX (for web), CMYK (for print), and Pantone (for brand-critical elements). Write these down. If your designer or printer has to guess, colors will shift between your website and your tub.

4. Two Typefaces. One display, one body. Name them explicitly, with the weight (Bold, SemiBold, Regular) you'll use for each application. License them properly if they're commercial fonts.

5. Three-Sentence Brand Manifesto. Who you serve, what you stand for, what you refuse to compromise on. Example: "Built for athletes who train across disciplines. Formulated with clinical doses and zero fillers. We don't hide behind proprietary blends." This is the tone check for every piece of copy you write.

Five Mistakes That Scream First-Time Founder

These anti-patterns instantly signal amateur. If your current label draft has any of them, fix it before Chapter 4.

Canva gradients and preset backgrounds. Canva's default gradient overlays are recognizable on sight by anyone in design or print. They mark your brand as a template. Use flat colors or custom textures instead.

Three or more typefaces. Every additional font adds visual noise and reduces perceived quality. Two typefaces, no exceptions.

Clip-art icons and stock vectors. Generic dumbbell icons, lightning bolts from icon packs, and Shutterstock vector art communicate "I didn't invest in this." Use custom iconography or none at all.

Drop shadows, bevels, and word-art effects on the product name. These effects dominated 2008-era supplement labels. In 2025, they signal your design reference points are a decade behind. Premium labels use flat type, sometimes with a subtle emboss or foil achieved through physical print finishes, not Photoshop layer styles.

Inconsistent color between web and print. If your Instagram looks navy and your tub arrives purple, your brand loses credibility on the first unboxing video. Lock CMYK and Pantone values before anything goes to print.

What to do now:

1. Choose your color direction from the table above.

Match it to the buyer archetype you selected in Chapter 2. Write down your primary color, secondary color, and one accent color in HEX and CMYK values.

2. Select two typefaces.

One bold display font (product name, callouts) and one clean body font (Supplement Facts, descriptions). Google Fonts is a free starting point. Montserrat + Inter is a reliable combination that works across print and web.

3. Pick your voice position from the voice matrix.

Write three sample label headlines for your product in that voice. If they sound forced, try the adjacent column. The right voice feels natural and specific to your buyer.

4. Write your three-sentence brand manifesto.

Sentence one: who you serve. Sentence two: what you stand for. Sentence three: what you refuse to do. This is your tone compass for every piece of copy from here on.

5. Audit your current assets against the five mistakes list.

If you have an existing logo or label draft, check it against each anti-pattern. Be honest. It's cheaper to fix this now than after a 2,500-unit print run.



Next: Chapter 4 — Premium vs. Generic: The Physical Differences That Justify a Higher Price

CHAPTER 4

Premium vs. Generic

The Physical Differences That Justify a Higher Price



Label Material: The Foundation Nobody Sees (Until It Fails)

The substrate your label is printed on determines how it holds color, whether it survives moisture, and how it feels in a customer's hand. Choose wrong and your label bubbles in a gym bag, peels at the edges, or prints with washed-out colors. Three materials matter.

Material	What It Is	Strengths	Weaknesses	Cost Per Label
BOPP Film	Biaxially Oriented Polypropylene. Thin, flexible plastic film.	Moisture-proof, excellent color reproduction, tear-resistant, industry standard for supplements	Cannot be recycled easily; limited tactile "paper" feel	\$0.12–\$0.45
Vinyl	PVC-based adhesive film. Thicker and more rigid than BOPP.	Extremely durable, conforms to curved surfaces, weather-resistant	More expensive, overkill for indoor retail products, harder to print fine detail at speed	\$0.30–\$0.75
Paper Stock	Coated or uncoated paper with adhesive backing.	Cheapest option, good for flat surfaces, premium "craft" feel when uncoated	Not moisture-resistant, wrinkles and peels on curved tubs, poor durability	\$0.08–\$0.25

The standard for sports supplements is white or clear BOPP film with a matte or gloss lamination. If a printer asks "what substrate?" and you say "BOPP with matte lam," you've already signaled that you know what you're doing. Paper stock is for craft candles, not creatine tubs.

Premium Print Finishes: Where the Money Shows

Finishes are the physical details that make a customer pick up your tub and turn it over. They are the single biggest differentiator between a product that looks like an Amazon commodity and one that feels like it belongs next to Ghost or CBUM.



Finish	What It Does	Best Used On	Added Cost Per Label
Soft-Touch Matte Lamination	Full-label coating that gives a velvety, almost suede-like texture when touched	Entire label surface. Creates a premium tactile base that other finishes sit on top of.	\$0.03–\$0.08
Spot UV	A glossy, raised clear coating applied to specific areas only (not the full label)	Logos, product names, icons. Creates contrast against a matte background.	\$0.05–\$0.15
Hot Foil Stamping	Metallic foil (gold, silver, holographic) physically pressed onto the label with a heated die	Brand name, logo mark, premium accents. The highest-impact finish.	\$0.10–\$0.30
Embossing / Debossing	Raised (emboss) or pressed-in (deboss) texture on the label surface	Logos, badge outlines, subtle texture patterns	\$0.08–\$0.20
Registered Cold Foil	Metallic foil applied inline during printing (faster and cheaper than hot foil at high volume)	Large metallic areas, backgrounds, full-panel effects	\$0.06–\$0.18

The highest-impact combination for a first-time founder: soft-touch matte lamination on the full label, spot UV on the logo and product name, and one hot-foil accent on the brand mark. Total added cost: roughly \$0.18–\$0.53 per label. On a tub retailing at \$39.99, that investment is invisible in your COGS and massive in your perceived value.

Shrink Sleeves vs. Pressure-Sensitive Labels

Pressure-sensitive labels are adhesive-backed labels applied directly to the container surface. They cover a portion of the tub (typically the front and back panels or a wraparound band). They are the industry standard for supplement tubs, cost less to produce, and have lower MOQs. Typical MOQ: 500–1,000 labels.



Shrink sleeves are printed plastic tubes that are heat-shrunk around the entire container for 360-degree coverage. They allow full-body artwork with no seams or edges. The result is visually striking, but the barrier to entry is higher. Shrink sleeves require custom tooling, a heat-tunnel application process, and MOQs typically starting at 5,000–10,000 units.

For your first production run, use pressure-sensitive labels on BOPP. Shrink sleeves are a scaling decision, not a launch decision. When your monthly volume consistently exceeds 5,000 units and you want a full-body design, that's when shrink sleeves become cost-effective.

Container and Closure: The Other Half of “Premium”

Your label can be flawless and your product still looks cheap if the tub, lid, and seal are generic. These details register subconsciously.

Tub finish matters. A matte-finish HDPE tub in black or white reads as premium. A glossy, translucent tub with visible powder through the walls reads as commodity. The cost difference is typically \$0.10–\$0.30 per unit. If you're selling at \$35+, always choose the matte-finish tub.

Lid and scoop color coordination. Your lid color should match your brand palette. A white tub with a neon green lid and a generic clear scoop says “stock catalog.” A matte black tub with a matching lid and branded scoop color says “every detail was intentional.” Ask your CM about custom lid color options; most offer them at modest upcharges.

Induction sealing is non-negotiable. An induction seal (the foil liner under the lid) signals tamper evidence and freshness. Products without one feel untrustworthy. Every reputable CM offers this as standard; confirm before placing your order.



The Shelf Test: Train Your

Reading about finishes is useful. Touching them is better. This exercise teaches more about premium

Go to a Vitamin Shoppe, GNC, or the supplement aisle of a well-stocked grocery store. Bring your phone. Pick up ten products at eye level and photograph

Is the label matte or glossy? Can you feel a raised texture on the logo (spot UV or emboss)? Is there metallic foil

anywhere? Is the label a pressure-sensitive wrap or a fullshrink sleeve? What does the tub itself feel like: matte, glossy, or soft-touch? Is there an induction seal under the lid?

Organize your photos into two groups: products that feel expensive and products that feel cheap. The patterns will be obvious. The expensive ones will have matte lamination, at least one accent finish, an opaque tub, and coordinated lid colors. The cheap ones will have glossy lam, no accents, translucent containers, and mismatched lids. Save those photos as your reference board for Chapters 8 and 10.

What to do now:

- 1. Decide your label configuration.** For your first run, the answer is almost certainly pressure-sensitive labels on white BOPP film with matte lamination. Write that down. It becomes part of the specification sheet you'll send to your printer in Chapter 10.
- 2. Choose your premium finish stack.** At minimum: soft-touch matte lamination (full label) + spot UV (logo and product name). If budget allows, add one hot-foil accent. Write down which elements get which finish. This is your finish specification.
- 3. Specify your container and closure.** Matte-finish HDPE tub, color-matched lid, induction seal. Ask your contract manufacturer for a sample of their tub options before committing to a production run. The \$20 cost of a sample order prevents a \$3,000 mistake.
- 4. Do the Shelf Test this week.** Go to a retail store, photograph ten products, and sort them into "premium" and "generic." Identify the specific finishes that drive the difference. Save the photos as your visual reference.
- 5. Build your finish specification one-liner.** Practice saying it: "White BOPP, soft-touch matte lam, spot UV on the logo, registered hot foil on the product name, pressure-sensitive application." That sentence is what you'll lead with when you contact printers in Chapter 10.

Next: Chapter 5 — Anatomy of a High-Converting Label: Premium Elements & Layout Hierarchy

CHAPTER 5

Anatomy of a High-Converting Label

Premium Elements & Layout Hierarchy



The Principal Display Panel: Five Zones in Exact Order

The Principal Display Panel (PDP) is the front of your label. It is the only part of your product most customers will ever see. Everything on this panel competes for attention, and the order in which a buyer's eye processes it determines whether they pick up the tub or move on.

Design your PDP in five visual priority zones, from top to bottom:

Priority	Element	What It Does	Design Guidance
1 (Top)	Brand Logo	Establishes brand recognition and trust	Upper 15–20% of PDP. Prominent but not dominant. Your logo introduces; the product name sells.
2	Product Name + Statement of Identity	Tells the buyer exactly what this product is ("Creatine Monohydrate Dietary Supplement")	Largest type on the label. Bold display font. This is the single element that must be readable from five feet away.
3	Hero Benefit Callout	Communicates the primary consumer outcome ("Build Strength. Recover Faster.")	2–3 words maximum. Positioned directly beneath or integrated with the product name. Benefit language, not ingredient language.
4	Key Differentiator Badges	Signals trust and category distinction ("Zero Sugar," "Third-Party Tested," "60 Servings")	Small, clean icons or text badges. Limit to 2–3 maximum. More than that creates clutter that cancels the premium effect.
5 (Bottom)	Net Quantity of Contents	FDA-required statement of weight or count ("Net Wt. 10.6 oz / 300g")	Lower 30% of PDP as required by law. Small but legible. Minimum 1/8 inch type for standard tub sizes.

If you squint at your label from arm's length and cannot immediately identify the product name and the hero benefit, your hierarchy is wrong. Rearrange until those two elements dominate.

Benefit-First Copywriting

Most first-time founders put the ingredient front and center: "5g Creatine Monohydrate" in big type across the tub. The problem: that only works on buyers who already know what creatine does. It tells the educated buyer nothing new and the curious buyer nothing useful.

Lead with the outcome, then support with the ingredient. “Build Strength. Recover Faster.” in the hero position, with “5g Creatine Monohydrate” in smaller supporting type below. The benefit catches the eye. The ingredient validates the claim. That two-step sequence is how premium labels convert browsers into buyers.

Use this formula for every callout on your PDP: [Consumer Outcome] supported by [Clinical Dose + Ingredient]. “Stay Sharp All Day” supported by “200mg L-Theanine + 100mg Caffeine.” “Complete Recovery” supported by “5g Creatine + 3.2g Beta-Alanine.” The outcome earns the pickup. The ingredient earns the purchase.

Trust Badges: Which Ones Matter

Certification badges can accelerate a purchase decision or create visual noise. The difference is relevance. Use the wrong ones and your label looks like a NASCAR sponsorship panel.

Badge / Certification	Buyer Impact	Worth the Space?
NSF Certified for Sport	High. Required by many pro athletes and collegiate programs. Strong trust signal for the Competitive Body-builder and Hybrid Athlete.	Yes, if you have it
Informed Sport	High. Recognized globally. Common on products targeting tested athletes.	Yes, if you have it
Third-Party Tested	Medium-High. Broad consumer trust, especially on Amazon where counterfeiting is a concern.	Yes
Non-GMO Project Verified	Medium. Strong with the Wellness Casual archetype. Less relevant for pre-workout.	If it fits your buyer
GMP Certified	Low-Medium. Expected baseline, not a differentiator. Buyers assume it.	Only if space allows
“All Natural” / “Clean”	Low. Legally undefined terms. Adds nothing credible. Educated buyers distrust them.	No

Place badges in the lower portion of your PDP or along the bottom edge. Two to three badges maximum. If you don’t have NSF or Informed Sport certification yet, “Third-Party Tested” is your strongest available signal for a first production run.

The Information Panel: Back-Label Architecture

The information panel (back or side of the label) is where FDA-required elements live. The goal here is compliance and readability, not selling. But a cluttered, cramped back panel makes the entire product feel cheap.

Layout order, top to bottom: Supplement Facts panel, Other Ingredients list, allergen declaration (“Contains:” statement), directions for use, warning/caution statements, the mandatory FDA disclaimer for any structure/function claims, distributor name and address, and lot/batch code with expiration date.

Formatting principles: Use a clean, 6-point minimum sans-serif typeface (Helvetica or equivalent, per FDA requirements). Maintain consistent margins. Separate sections with clear spacing or thin hairline rules, not decorative dividers. Leave enough white space that the panel looks intentional, not crammed. A well-organized back panel signals the same care and precision as the front.

Common mistake: designing the front label first and treating the back panel as an afterthought, forcing legal text into whatever space remains. Design both panels simultaneously. The Supplement Facts panel alone can require 30–40% of your information panel area.

The Three-Second Shelf Test

A shopper in a retail aisle or scrolling a product listing gives your label roughly three seconds before deciding to pick it up or keep moving. In that window, your label must communicate three things: the brand, the product, and the primary benefit. If any of those three requires effort to identify, you lose the sale.

Test it yourself. Open your label file on your phone. Set a three-second timer. Show it to someone who has never seen your product. After three seconds, ask: “What brand is this? What product is it? What does it do for me?” If they can answer all three, your hierarchy is working. If they hesitate on any one, redesign that element.

The brands that win this test share common traits. The product name is the largest element. There is one hero benefit, not four competing callouts. The color palette reads as one cohesive identity. Negative space exists between elements so nothing competes for the same attention. Simplicity at three seconds, depth on closer inspection.

What to do now:

1. **Sketch your PDP using the five-zone hierarchy.** You don't need design software. A piece of paper or a whiteboard works. Place your logo in zone 1, product name in zone 2, hero benefit in zone 3, two to three badges in zone 4, and net quantity in zone 5. This sketch becomes the wireframe you hand to your designer.
2. **Rewrite your front-label copy using the benefit-first formula.** [Consumer Outcome] supported by [Clinical Dose + Ingredient]. Write three variations. Pick the one that reads fastest and communicates the clearest benefit in the fewest words.
3. **Select your trust badges.** Choose two to three from the table that match your buyer archetype and your current certification status. If you have no certifications yet, lead with "Third-Party Tested" and plan for NSF or Informed Sport on your second production run.
4. **Map your information panel layout.** List every required back-panel element in the order specified above. Estimate the space each element needs. Design this alongside your PDP, not after it.
5. **Run the three-second test on your current draft.** Show your label to three people for three seconds each. If they cannot name the brand, product, and benefit, your hierarchy needs adjustment before you move to Chapter 6.

Next: Chapter 6 — FDA Compliance: Building a Supplement Label That Won't Get You Sued



CHAPTER 6

FDA Compliance

Building a Supplement Label That Won't Get You Sued



Six Elements the FDA Requires on Every Supplement Label

Federal law under 21 CFR Part 101 and the Dietary Supplement Health and Education Act (DSHEA) mandates six elements on every dietary supplement label sold in the United States. Missing any one is grounds for an FDA warning letter, a retailer rejection, or both.

Element	What It Means	Placement
1. Statement of Identity	The product's common name plus "dietary supplement" (e.g., "Creatine Monohydrate Dietary Supplement")	Principal Display Panel (front)
2. Net Quantity	Total amount by weight, measure, or count (e.g., "Net Wt. 10.6 oz (300g)" or "60 Capsules")	PDP, lower 30%
3. Supplement Facts Panel	Structured panel: serving size, servings per container, each ingredient, amount per serving, % Daily Value	Information Panel (back/side)
4. Other Ingredients	All non-active ingredients (fillers, flavors, colors) in descending order of predominance	Below or beside Supplement Facts
5. Name & Place of Business	Name, city, state, and ZIP of manufacturer, packer, or distributor	Information Panel
6. Directions for Use	Dosage instructions (e.g., "Mix one scoop with 8–12 oz water. Take once daily.")	Information Panel

Net quantity type size is regulated by PDP area. For a PDP between 5 and 25 square inches (standard supplement tub), minimum type size is 1/8 inch (roughly 9 points). Smaller than that and your label is non-compliant, even if everything else is correct.

Building the Supplement Facts Panel

The Supplement Facts panel is the most technically demanding element on your label. The formatting rules under 21 CFR 101.36 are specific, and retail buyers will reject a label that gets them wrong.

Typeface and size. The panel must use Helvetica, Helvetica Black, or an equivalent sans-serif. Minimum size for most text is 6 points. The header "Supplement Facts" must be larger than all other panel text and set in bold.

Bolding rules. Only “Supplement Facts,” “Serving Size,” “Servings Per Container,” “Amount Per Serving,” and “% Daily Value” are bolded. Individual nutrient names are NOT bolded. This is the opposite of what most people assume and one of the most common formatting violations.

The † dagger symbol. Ingredients with no established Daily Value (creatine, beta-alanine, citrulline) get a † in the % DV column and the footnote: “† Daily Value not established.”

Proprietary blends. If you use one, list the total blend weight followed by each ingredient in descending order by weight. Individual amounts are not required. However, the strong recommendation: skip proprietary blends entirely. Transparent dosing is a competitive advantage, and serious buyers actively distrust “prop blends.”

Structure/Function Claims vs. Drug Claims

This is where founders receive warning letters. The distinction is simple in theory and dangerous in practice.



A structure/function claim describes an ingredient's role in maintaining normal body structure or function. Legal examples: “Supports muscle recovery.” “Helps maintain healthy joints.” “Promotes focus and mental clarity.”

A drug claim states or implies the product can diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent a disease. Illegal examples: “Cures joint pain.” “Prevents muscle atrophy.” “Treats insomnia.” Even “relieves” can cross the line when paired with a disease condition.

Legal (Structure/Function)	Illegal (Drug Claim)
“Supports muscle recovery”	“Cures muscle soreness”
“Helps maintain energy levels”	“Treats chronic fatigue”
“Promotes joint flexibility”	“Prevents arthritis”
“Supports a healthy immune system”	“Boosts immunity to prevent illness”

Two requirements for any structure/function claim. First, file a notification with the FDA within 30 days of first marketing (a simple form, not an approval process). Second, your label must carry this exact disclaimer in bold:

“This statement has not been evaluated by the Food and Drug Administration. This product is not intended to diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent any disease.”

That disclaimer must appear in direct connection with the claim, on the same panel. Burying it in 4-point type on the bottom of the tub does not satisfy the requirement.

Allergen Declarations

FALCPA plus the FASTER Act (effective January 1, 2023) require declaration of nine major allergens: milk, eggs, fish, crustacean shellfish, tree nuts, peanuts, wheat, soybeans, and sesame. If your product contains any of these or is manufactured on shared equipment, you must declare it.

The standard format is a “Contains:” statement immediately after the Other Ingredients list. Example: “Contains: milk, soy.” For cross-contamination risk, add: “Manufactured in a facility that also processes tree nuts and sesame.”

Sesame is the newest addition (2023, FASTER Act) and the one most often missed on supplement labels. If your CM processes any sesame-containing product on shared equipment, your label needs a cross-contamination advisory. Ask them directly.

cGMP: What It Means for Your Label

Current Good Manufacturing Practice regulations under 21 CFR Part 111 govern how dietary supplements are manufactured, packaged, labeled, and stored. As a brand owner, you are legally responsible for cGMP compliance even if you outsource production entirely.

Three practical implications. First, every label claim (ingredient amounts, potency, purity) must be supported by batch testing records. If your label says “5g Creatine Monohydrate” per serving, testing must confirm it. Second, your manufacturer must maintain identity testing for incoming ingredients and written records for every batch. Third, keep copies yourself. “My manufacturer handles that” is not a legal defense.

Before your first production run, request your CM's most recent FDA inspection report (Form 483) and a sample Certificate of Analysis (COA). If they hesitate to provide either, find a different manufacturer.

What to do now:

- 1. Verify all six mandatory elements on your label draft.** Use the table above as a checklist. Statement of Identity with “dietary supplement,” net quantity in the lower 30% of the PDP, Supplement Facts panel, Other Ingredients, business name/address, directions for use. Add anything missing.
- 2. Format your Supplement Facts panel to 21 CFR 101.36.** Helvetica or equivalent at 6-point minimum. Bold only header elements, not nutrient names. † dagger with footnote for ingredients without an established Daily Value. Chapter 7 provides AI prompts that audit your panel line by line.
- 3. Audit every claim against the legal/illegal table.** If any claim implies the product diagnoses, treats, cures, or prevents a disease, rewrite it as a structure/function claim. Add the mandatory disclaimer in bold on the same panel.
- 4. Confirm allergen status with your CM.** Ask specifically about sesame and cross-contamination from shared equipment. Add a “Contains:” statement after Other Ingredients if applicable.
- 5. Request your CM's FDA Form 483 and a sample COA.** File them. They are your proof of cGMP compliance if questioned by a retailer, a competitor, or the FDA.

Next: Chapter 7 — Quality Control: AI-Powered Label Auditing Before You Send to Print

CHAPTER 7

Quality Control

AI-Powered Label Auditing Before You Send to Print



The Three-Pass QC System

A single read-through of your label is not quality control. It is how you miss the error that costs \$3,000 in reprinted labels. Professional CPG brands run multiple audit passes, each with a different focus. You should do the same.

Pass 1: Regulatory Compliance. Check only for FDA-mandated elements. Are all six required elements present (Chapter 6)? Is the Supplement Facts panel formatted to 21 CFR 101.36? Is the net quantity in the correct position with compliant type size? Is the mandatory disclaimer present on the same panel as any structure/function claim? Is the allergen declaration complete? Ignore design and copy during this pass.

Pass 2: Copy and Claims Audit. Now check the words. Does every claim avoid disease language (Chapter 6 table)? Are ingredient names spelled using USP or INCI conventions (“Citrulline Malate,” not “cit malate”)? Check serving size math: servings per container multiplied by scoop size must equal the net weight on the PDP.

Pass 3: Design and Print Integrity. Check color mode (CMYK, not RGB). Confirm all text is outlined or embedded. Verify 0.125-inch bleed on all edges. Check barcode placement: minimum 0.25-inch quiet zone on all sides, scan it with a phone app. Confirm the dieline matches your printer's template.

Run each pass as a separate read-through. Trying to catch regulatory errors and design errors simultaneously is how you catch neither.

Three AI Audit Prompts You Can Copy and Paste

Paste these prompts into Claude, ChatGPT, or any capable AI assistant. Copy your complete label text (every word from both the PDP and information panel) and paste it after each prompt.

PROMPT 1: Full Regulatory Scan

I am launching a dietary supplement in the United States. Below is the complete text from my product label. Audit this label against 21 CFR Part 101 and DSHEA requirements for dietary supplements. Check for: (1) presence of all six mandatory label elements (Statement of Identity, Net Quantity, Supplement Facts panel, Other Ingredients list, Name and Place of Business, Directions for Use), (2) correct Supplement Facts for-

matting under 21 CFR 101.36 including bolding rules and dagger symbols, (3) proper allergen declarations under FALCPA and the FASTER Act including all nine major allergens, (4) presence of the mandatory FDA disclaimer if any structure/function claims are made. Return a numbered list of every issue found, with the specific regulation violated and a corrected version of the text. If no issues are found for a category, state that it passes. Here is my label text: [PASTE FULL LABEL TEXT HERE]

PROMPT 2: Claims Violation Detector

Review the following dietary supplement label text and identify every claim that could be classified as a drug claim under FDA regulations. A drug claim is any statement that implies the product can diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent a disease. For each flagged claim, explain why it crosses the line from a permitted structure/function claim into a prohibited drug claim, and provide a rewritten version that is compliant. Also flag any use of the phrase "FDA approved" or "clinically proven" which are not permitted on dietary supplement labels. Here is my label text: [PASTE FULL LABEL TEXT HERE]

PROMPT 3: Supplement Facts Panel Formatter

I need to verify that my Supplement Facts panel is formatted correctly under 21 CFR 101.36. Review the panel text below and check: (1) Is "Supplement Facts" the largest and boldest text? (2) Are only the required header elements bolded (Supplement Facts, Serving Size, Servings Per Container, Amount Per Serving, % Daily Value) and NOT individual nutrient names? (3) Does every ingredient without an established Daily Value have a dagger symbol (†) with the footnote "Daily Value not established"? (4) Are ingredients listed using correct USP or INCI nomenclature? (5) If a proprietary blend is present, is the total blend weight listed with ingredients in descending order of predominance? Flag every error and provide the corrected formatting. Here is my Supplement Facts panel text: [PASTE PANEL TEXT HERE]

Run all three prompts separately. Each catches a different category of error. An AI audit is not a substitute for a regulatory attorney on high-stakes launches, but for a first run of 500 to 2,500 units, it catches the errors behind 90% of FDA warning letters.

Errors That Trigger FDA Warning Letters

These violations appear repeatedly in real FDA enforcement actions. If your label has any of them, it will eventually be flagged.

Error	Why It Gets Flagged	How to Fix It
Missing/undersized net quantity	Violates 21 CFR 101.105. Most basic compliance failure.	Verify PDP area. Apply minimum 1/8-inch type for 5–25 sq in PDP.
Disease claims as structure/function	"Reduces inflammation" or "prevents muscle damage" are disease claims.	Rewrite: "Supports healthy inflammatory response" or "Supports muscle recovery."

Error	Why It Gets Flagged	How to Fix It
"FDA Approved" on label	FDA does not approve dietary supplements. Automatic warning letter.	Remove. Use "Manufactured in an FDA-registered, cGMP-compliant facility" instead.
Missing allergen declaration	Especially sesame (added 2023). Triggers FDA action and lawsuits.	Add "Contains:" statement. Confirm shared-equipment risks with CM.
Supplement Facts bolding errors	Bolding nutrient names instead of header elements only.	Bold only: Supplement Facts, Serving Size, Servings Per Container, Amount Per Serving, % Daily Value.

The Pre-Print Approval Checklist

Four people should sign off before your label file goes to the printer. If you are a solo founder wearing all four hats, sign off four separate times on four separate read-throughs.

Reviewer	What They Check	Sign-Off Confirms
Formulator / CM	Ingredient names, amounts, and serving size match batch formula	Label matches Certificate of Analysis
Regulatory reviewer	Six mandatory elements present, claims compliant, allergens declared, disclaimer positioned	Label will not trigger a warning letter
Designer	CMYK mode, text outlined, bleed set, barcode scannable, dieline matches printer spec, 300+ DPI	File is print-ready
Founder (you)	Brand voice consistent, no typos, everything reads as intended	This is the label you want on 2,500 tubs

Document each sign-off with a date, reviewer name, and file version number. A shared spreadsheet works. This record protects you if a dispute arises with your printer, your CM, or a retail buyer.



What to do now:

1. **Run Pass 1 (Regulatory) on your label draft.** Check only for the six mandatory elements and Supplement Facts formatting. Mark every issue without fixing anything yet.
2. **Run Pass 2 (Copy/Claims) and Pass 3 (Design/Print) as separate read-throughs.** By the end you have a complete issue list across all three categories.
3. **Run all three AI prompts with your label text.** Copy and paste each prompt individually. Compare the AI output against your manual findings. The AI catches items you missed; your review catches context the AI missed.
4. **Fix every issue, then re-audit the corrected version.** QC is not one-and-done. The corrected label gets a fresh pass through all three checks and all three prompts. Repeat until everything returns clean.
5. **Complete the pre-print sign-off.** Documented approval from formulator/CM,

Next: Chapter 8 — Print File Preparation: Getting Your Label Production-Ready

CHAPTER 8

Print File Preparation

Engineering Your Label for the Press



Dielines: The Blueprint Your Printer Requires

A dieline is a vector outline that defines the exact shape and dimensions of your label, including where it will be cut, folded, or die-cut. Think of it as the architectural blueprint for your label. If your dieline is wrong, the printer produces labels that don't fit your container. The entire run becomes scrap.

Where to get one. Your printer should provide a dieline template specific to your container and label type. Request it before you start designing. If you are working with a contract manufacturer who handles label application, they will have the dieline for the tubs they stock. Never guess the dimensions.

How to set it up. In Adobe Illustrator, place the dieline on its own locked layer at the top of your layer stack. Set the stroke to a spot color (typically "Dieline" in magenta or a non-printing color) so the printer knows it is a cut path, not artwork. Your design layers sit beneath it. Nothing in the artwork layer should reference the dieline color.

Bleed, Safety Zone, and Trim

These three zones prevent two problems: white edges where color should bleed to the edge, and text getting cut off during trimming. Every commercial printer requires them.

Zone	What It Is	Standard Dimension	Rule
Bleed	The area OUTSIDE the trim line where background colors and images extend	0.125" (1/8 inch) beyond trim on all sides	All backgrounds and edge-to-edge graphics must extend into bleed. No text, no logos.
Trim Line	The exact line where the label will be cut	Matches dieline dimensions	This is your label's true edge. Nothing critical sits directly on it.
Safety Zone	The area INSIDE the trim line where all critical content must stay	0.125" (1/8 inch) inset from trim	All text, logos, barcodes, and regulatory elements must remain inside this boundary.

Real scenario: A founder sends a file with their product name running to the edge of the label with no safety margin. The press trims 1/16" off-register (normal tolerance), and

the bottom of every letter on 2,500 labels is sliced. \$3,200 in labels, unusable. Safety zones exist for exactly this reason.

CMYK vs. RGB: Why Your Screen Lies

Your monitor displays color in RGB (red, green, blue light). Commercial printers print in CMYK (cyan, magenta, yellow, black ink). RGB has a wider color gamut than CMYK, which means colors that look vibrant on screen will print duller, muddier, or shifted if you don't convert them.

Set up correctly from the start. When creating a new Illustrator document, set the color mode to CMYK (File > New > Color Mode: CMYK). If you are working on an existing RGB file, convert it (File > Document Color Mode > CMYK Color). After converting, visually check every color. Bright neon greens and electric blues are the biggest offenders; they shift dramatically.

Use Pantone spot colors for brand-critical elements. Your logo and primary brand color should be specified as a Pantone (PMS) spot color, not a CMYK build. Pantone inks are pre-mixed to an exact standard, so your brand color matches perfectly across every print run and every printer. Tell your printer which elements are spot colors in your spec sheet. Expect a modest upcharge for each spot color plate.

Vectorize Everything

Fonts, logos, and icons must be converted to vector outlines before you send the file. If your printer's system doesn't have the exact font installed, it substitutes a default, and your premium Bebas Neue headline becomes Times New Roman. The fix is permanent and simple.

Convert text to outlines. Select All (Cmd/Ctrl + A), then Type > Create Outlines (Cmd/Ctrl + Shift + O). This converts every character into a vector shape. The text is no longer editable as text, so always keep an editable backup copy of your file before outlining.

Logos must be vector. If your logo only exists as a PNG or JPEG, it is a raster image and will print with visible pixelation at any reasonable size. Your logo must be in .AI, .

EPS, or .SVG format. If you don't have a vector version, getting one recreated by a designer is a \$50–\$150 investment that you cannot skip.

Raster images: 300 DPI minimum at print size. Any photographic element (ingredient photos, background textures) must be 300 DPI at the size it will print. A photo that looks sharp on screen at 72 DPI will print blurry. Check resolution in Illustrator: Window > Links, select the image, and verify the effective PPI is 300 or above.

Packaging Your File for the Printer

A print-ready submission is not a single file. It is a folder containing everything the printer needs to produce your label without calling you.

Step 1: Package the Illustrator file. File > Package. Illustrator collects the .AI file, all linked images, and all fonts into a single folder. This ensures the printer has every asset, even if the file references external images or typefaces.

Step 2: Export a PDF/X-4 proof. File > Save As > Adobe PDF. Under the Adobe PDF Preset dropdown, select PDF/X-4. This format embeds all fonts, preserves transparency, and ensures CMYK color accuracy. It is the standard the printing industry expects. Do not send a standard PDF or a “Press Quality” PDF unless your printer specifically requests it.

Step 3: Include a finish specification sheet. A single-page document (Word or PDF) listing: substrate (e.g., White BOPP), lamination (e.g., Soft-Touch Matte), finish callouts with reference to labeled areas (e.g., “Spot UV on logo and product name,” “Hot foil stamp on brand mark, Pantone 871C Gold”), label dimensions, quantity, and any Pantone spot colors used. This sheet removes ambiguity and eliminates back-and-forth.



Artwork

White Mask

Your final submission folder should contain: the packaged .AI folder (with Links and Fonts subfolders), the PDF/X-4 proof, and the finish specification sheet. Label the folder clearly: [BrandName]_[ProductName]_LabelFiles_v[X]. That naming convention signals professionalism before the printer even opens the file.

What to do now:

- 1. Request a dieline template from your printer or CM.** Do this before you design anything. Place it on a locked top layer in Illustrator with a non-printing spot color stroke.
- 2. Set your Illustrator document to CMYK and verify bleed.** File > Document Setup > Bleed: 0.125" on all sides. Confirm all artwork extends into bleed and all critical content stays inside the safety zone.
- 3. Convert all text to outlines and verify image resolution.** Select All > Type > Create Outlines. Check every linked image via Window > Links for 300+ DPI at print size. Replace any raster logo with a vector version.
- 4. Package and export.** File > Package to collect all assets. File > Save As > PDF/X-4 for your proof. Create a one-page finish specification sheet listing substrate, lamination, spot finishes, Pantone colors, dimensions, and quantity.
- 5. Name and organize your submission folder.**
[BrandName]_[ProductName]_LabelFiles_v1 containing: packaged .AI folder, PDF/X-4 proof, finish spec sheet. This is what you send to your printer in Chapter 10.

Next: Chapter 9 — Retail Readiness: Barcodes, Certifications & Wholesale Packaging Standards

CHAPTER 9

Getting Retail-Ready

Preparing for Big-Box Sales Channels



What Retail Buyers Evaluate First

A category buyer at Vitamin Shoppe or GNC is not your Instagram follower. They evaluate products in a specific hierarchy, and failing at any level ends the conversation before you get to pitch your formula.

Priority	What They Check	What Kills the Deal
1. Packaging Quality	Does the label look professional? Premium finishes, consistent branding, no amateur design tells.	Canva-quality graphics, mismatched fonts, glossy lamination on a "premium" product.
2. Barcode Compliance	Valid GS1-registered UPC. Scannable. Properly placed with quiet zones.	Resold third-party barcodes, barcodes that fail scan tests, missing quiet zones.
3. Margin Structure	Wholesale cost allows the retailer 40–50% gross margin at the retail price.	Wholesale price too high for the retailer to hit standard markup.
4. Velocity Data	Evidence the product sells: DTC revenue, Amazon BSR, social proof, subscription numbers.	No sales history. "We haven't launched yet" is not a pitch.
5. Insurance & Compliance	Product liability insurance (\$1M–\$2M policy), FDA-compliant label, cGMP documentation.	No insurance certificate, non-compliant label, no COA on file.

Notice that formula and ingredients are not on this list. Buyers assume the product works. Their job is to evaluate whether it will sell and whether carrying it creates liability for the retailer. Your packaging is the first and most visible data point.

UPC/EAN Barcode Requirements

Register with GS1 directly. Go to gs1us.org and purchase a GS1 Company Prefix. This costs \$250 for the initial registration (for up to 10 products) plus a \$50 annual renewal. This prefix is yours. You use it to generate unique UPC-A barcodes (12 digits, standard for U.S. retail) for each SKU.

Do not buy barcodes from third-party resellers like cheap barcode sites. Retailers run GS1 validation checks. A resold barcode traces back to another company, not yours. GNC, Vitamin Shoppe, Amazon, and Whole Foods will all reject it. A founder recently had a 3,000-unit run rejected by a regional chain because the barcode prefix belonged to a liquidation company. The labels had to be reprinted.

Placement rules. The barcode must have a minimum 0.25-inch quiet zone (blank space) on all four sides. Place it on a flat, non-curved section of the label with a light background (white or very light color) behind the bars. Dark backgrounds behind barcodes cause scan failures. Size the barcode between 80% and 200% of the GS1 nominal size (1.469" wide x 1.02" tall at 100%).

UPC-A is the standard for U.S. retail. If you plan to sell internationally, you will also need an EAN-13 (13-digit) barcode, which your GS1 prefix supports. For a DTC-only launch, UPC-A is sufficient.

Case Packs and Shelf Configuration

Retailers don't order individual tubs. They order case packs. Your case-pack configuration affects shelf space allocation, reorder efficiency, and whether a buyer even considers your product.

Standard configurations: 6-unit case packs for premium or large-format products (tubs), 12-unit for mid-size (bottles, canisters), 24-unit for small-format (stick packs, sample sizes). Ask the buyer what configuration they prefer. If you guess wrong, they pass.

Labeling requirements: Each master case needs a separate barcode (an ITF-14, which is your UPC wrapped in a thicker bar pattern for warehouse scanning), the product name, flavor/variant, unit count, and lot/batch number printed or stickered on at least two sides. Inner packs (if any) need their own UPC and count labeling.



If you plan to pitch retailers within your first year, configure your case packs during your initial production run. Retrofitting loose inventory into labeled case packs later is expensive and time-consuming.

MAP Pricing and Channel Conflict

Minimum Advertised Price (MAP) is a policy you set that prevents retailers and online resellers from advertising your product below a specified price. Without MAP, a discount retailer can undercut your Shopify store, and your DTC customers feel punished for buying direct.

How to structure it. Set your MAP at or near your DTC retail price. If you sell a tub at \$39.99 on your website, your MAP should be \$39.99. Wholesale pricing to retailers is typically 50% off MAP (so \$20.00 per unit at wholesale), giving the retailer a 50% margin when they sell at MAP. Your COGS must support this. If your all-in cost per unit is \$8, your wholesale at \$20 gives you a \$12 gross margin per unit.

Draft a one-page MAP agreement that states the minimum advertised price, the consequences of violation (typically suspension of wholesale account), and the effective date. Have a lawyer review it once. You will use this same document with every wholesale account.

Certifications That Open Retail Doors

Certification	What It Proves	Required By	Cost / Timeline
NSF Certified for Sport	Product tested for 280+ banned substances. Gold standard for athletic markets.	Many pro sports leagues, collegiate programs, Vitamin Shoppe preferred	\$2,500–\$7,000/yr per SKU; 2–4 months
Informed Sport	Third-party banned-substance testing. Globally recognized.	International retailers, UK/EU markets, athletic organizations	\$2,000–\$5,000/yr per SKU; 2–3 months
Non-GMO Project Verified	Product and supply chain verified free of GMOs.	Whole Foods (strongly preferred), natural grocers, wellness retailers	\$2,000–\$5,000 initial; 3–6 months
USDA Organic	Ingredients and processing meet USDA organic standards.	Whole Foods, Sprouts, natural channel retailers	\$5,000–\$15,000+ initial; 6–12 months

You do not need all of these to launch. For a first production run sold DTC, “Third-Party Tested” on your label is sufficient. When you are ready to pitch a specific retailer, check their vendor requirements and invest in the certification they care about. NSF Certified for Sport opens the most doors in the sports nutrition channel.

What to do now:

- 1. Register your GS1 Company Prefix at gs1us.org.** \$250 initial, \$50/year. Generate UPC-A barcodes for each SKU. Do this now even if you are launching DTC-only; you will need it for Amazon and every retail channel.

2. **Price your product for wholesale from day one.** Work backwards: if MAP is \$39.99, wholesale is ~\$20, your COGS must be under \$10 to maintain viable margins across both DTC and retail. If the math doesn't work, adjust your product cost or retail price before printing labels.
3. **Decide on case-pack configuration.** Ask your CM about standard case sizes for your container. Default to 6-unit cases for tubs. Add ITF-14 barcodes and case labeling to your production spec sheet.
4. **Draft a one-page MAP agreement.** MAP price, violation consequences, effective date. Have it reviewed once by a lawyer. This document protects your DTC pricing and every future wholesale relationship.
5. **Identify your target retail channel's required certification.** If you're aiming for Vitamin Shoppe or sports nutrition specialty, prioritize NSF Certified for Sport. For natural grocers or Whole Foods, prioritize Non-GMO Project Verified. Budget and timeline for certification into your second production run.

Next: Chapter 10 — Speaking to Printers & Manufacturers Like a Veteran

CHAPTER 10

Speaking to Printers & Manufacturers Like a Veteran

Vocabulary, Questions & Negotiation Scripts



The Vocabulary That Signals Experience

Printers and CMs make snap judgments about clients. If you email asking about “sticker printing” for your “protein jar,” you have immediately identified yourself as someone they can overcharge or deprioritize. Use the correct terms and you are treated as a serious operator from the first interaction.

Term	What It Means	Use It Like This
Substrate	The material your label is printed on (BOPP, vinyl, paper)	“We need pricing on white BOPP substrate with matte lamination.”
Die-Cut	A custom-shaped cut (non-rectangular label)	“Is the die-cut charge per-order or amortized across runs?”
Gang Run	Multiple jobs printed together to reduce per-unit cost	“Do you offer gang-run pricing for orders under 2,500?”
Plate Charge	One-time setup fee for creating printing plates	“What’s your plate charge, and is it waived on reorders?”
Hard Proof	A physical printed sample for color and finish approval	“I need a hard proof before the full run. What’s the turnaround?”
Overrun / Under-run	Extra or fewer units produced beyond the order quantity (industry standard: $\pm 10\%$)	“What’s your overrun/underrun tolerance, and do I pay for overruns?”

12 Questions for Every Label Printer

Ask all of these before committing to a printer. The answers reveal capability, reliability, and whether they are set up to handle supplement-specific requirements.

Pricing and minimums: What is your MOQ? What is the per-unit price at 1,000 / 2,500 / 5,000 / 10,000 units? Is the plate charge one-time or per-run? Do you offer gang-run pricing?

Production: What is your standard turnaround from proof approval to delivery? Do you print on BOPP film? Can you apply soft-touch matte lamination, spot UV, and hot foil in a single run? What is your overrun/underrun tolerance, and am I billed for overruns?

Proofing and quality: Do you offer hard proofs or only digital proofs? What file format do you require (PDF/X-4, native .AI)? Can you provide a press check where I

approve the first sheets before the full run continues? Can you send three client references for supplement brands?

Red flag: if a printer quotes you without asking about your substrate, finish requirements, or dieline, they are guessing. A good printer asks as many questions as you do.

8 Questions for Every Contract Manufacturer

These questions protect your money, your compliance, and your IP.

Compliance and quality: Is your facility cGMP-certified under 21 CFR Part 111? Can you provide your most recent FDA Form 483? Do you use ISO 17025-accredited labs for COA testing? What does your COA test for (identity, potency, heavy metals, microbial)?

Operations and IP: What is your MOQ for a pilot run vs. a full production run? What is your standard lead time from PO to delivery? Will you sign an NDA and IP assignment for custom formulations? Do you handle label application in-house, or do I ship labels separately?

Negotiating MOQs and Pricing

Request a pilot run. Most CMs have a standard MOQ of 2,500–5,000 units. Many will run 500–1,000 at a 15–25% premium per unit if you frame it correctly: “We want to validate this SKU before committing to a full production run. Can you quote 500 units as a pilot, with pricing at 2,500 for the reorder?” This signals that you are planning to scale, not that you cannot afford a full run.

Ask for tiered pricing in writing. Always request quotes at three quantity levels (e.g., 1,000 / 2,500 / 5,000). This gives you a price curve and negotiating context. If the per-unit drop from 2,500 to 5,000 is only \$0.03, the larger order may not be worth the upfront cash.

Negotiate plate charges and setup fees. Plate charges (\$150–\$500) are often waived or reduced if you commit to a reorder. Ask: “If we commit to a reorder within 90 days, can you waive the plate charge on the first run?” This costs the printer almost nothing and saves you real money.

Three Copy-Paste Email Scripts

EMAIL 1: Initial Outreach to a Label Printer

Subject: RFQ – Pressure-Sensitive Labels for Supplement TubHi [Name], I'm sourcing a label printer for a sports nutrition brand launching [product]. I'd like a quote for the following specification: • Substrate: White BOPP • Finish: Soft-touch matte lamination, spot UV on logo and product name • Size: [dimensions from dieline] • Quantities: 1,000 / 2,500 / 5,000 • Application: Pressure-sensitive • Artwork: Print-ready PDF/X-4 with dieline on separate layer Can you also confirm: plate charges, turnaround from proof approval, over-run tolerance, and whether you offer hard proofs? I can send the artwork file once we're aligned on specs. Thanks.

EMAIL 2: Initial Outreach to a Contract Manufacturer

Subject: Production Inquiry – [Product Category] SupplementHi [Name], I'm evaluating CMs for a [product type] supplement. I'd like to discuss: • Pilot run of 500–1,000 units, with pricing at 2,500 for reorder • Flavor options and formulation support • cGMP certification status and most recent FDA 483 availability • COA protocol (lab accreditation, what's tested) • In-house label application capabilities and finish support • Standard lead time from PO to delivery • NDA/IP terms for custom formulations I have a print-ready label file and can share a target formula. What's the best way to get a formal quote started?

EMAIL 3: Follow-Up Negotiation

Subject: Re: Quote – Follow-Up on Pricing and TermsHi [Name], Thanks for the quote. Two questions before we move forward: 1. If we commit to a reorder within 90 days, can the plate/setup charge on this first run be waived or credited toward the second order? 2. We're comparing quotes at 2,500 units. Can you sharpen the per-unit price if we guarantee a 12-month volume commitment of [X] total units across [Y] reorders? We're ready to move quickly once terms are finalized. Appreciate your time.

What to do now:

- 1. Identify three label printers and three contract manufacturers.** Search for supplement-specific vendors, not general printers. Ask in founder communities, check supplier directories (ThomasNet, NutraCap Labs, Maker's Row), and request referrals from other brand owners.
- 2. Send Email 1 to all three printers and Email 2 to all three CMs.** Customize the product details but keep the structure. Sending to three vendors gives you comparison data and negotiating power.

3. **Compare quotes using the 12 and 8 question frameworks.** Don't evaluate on price alone. A printer who is \$0.02 cheaper per label but doesn't offer hard proofs or has a 20% overrun tolerance will cost you more in the long run.
4. **Send Email 3 to your top candidate.** Negotiate plate charges and volume commitments. The first vendor to respond with flexibility and clear answers is usually the one you want to work with.
5. **Request samples before committing.** Ask your top printer for a sample of their work on BOPP with matte lamination. Ask your top CM for a sample tub with their standard lid and induction seal. Evaluate both in hand before signing a PO.

Next: Chapter 11 — Product Mockups: Creating Photorealistic Images Before Production

Product Mockups

THE RIPPED STACK



Why Mockups Are a Non-Negotiable Pre-Launch Asset

Your manufacturer's lead time is 4–8 weeks. If you wait until the physical product arrives to start marketing, you are burning a month or more of potential revenue and audience-building. The brands that sell out their first run don't wait. They launch the marketing while the product is still in production.

Photorealistic 3D mockups let you build a Shopify store with professional product images, run pre-launch email capture campaigns, seed products to influencers with visual assets, and pitch retailers with a sell sheet that looks like an established brand. Every one of these activities can happen while your tubs are still on the production line.

A founder waited until his 500-unit run arrived to shoot product photos. It took another two weeks to get the shots edited and uploaded. By the time his store was live, the launch hype from his Instagram teaser posts had gone cold. His first 30 days of sales were half what he projected. The fix was simple: mockups ready before the product ships.

DIY Mockup Tools

Not every founder needs (or can afford) a professional 3D artist. Here are the most accessible options, ranked by quality ceiling and learning curve.

Tool	What It Does	Quality Ceiling	Cost
Photoshop Smart Objects	Apply your label to a pre-built PSD tub template. Drag, drop, save.	High, if you buy premium templates from Creative Market or Envato.	\$15–\$40 per template + Photoshop subscription
Placeit / Smart-mockups	Browser-based generators. Upload your label, select a scene, export.	Medium. Limited tub shapes and angles. Fine for social; weak for Shopify hero.	\$8/mockup or ~\$15/month subscription
Blender (Free 3D Software)	Full 3D modeling and rendering. Build your tub from scratch in exact dimensions.	Professional studio quality. No ceiling.	Free software, but steep learning curve (20+ hours to competency)

For most first-time founders, Photoshop smart-object templates are the best balance of quality and speed. Buy two or three premium tub mockup files from Creative Market, drop in your label artwork, and you have hero-quality images in under an hour.

AI-Generated Photorealistic Mockups

AI image generation tools can now produce studio-quality product renders in custom environments, with controlled lighting and realistic materials. The key is writing detailed prompts that specify the product, the surface, the lighting direction, and the mood.

Vague prompts produce vague results.

Below are three prompt configurations you can adapt to your product. Each targets a different use case. Modify the product description, colors, and label details to match your brand.

PROMPT 1: Clean Studio Shot (Shopify Hero Image)

Photorealistic product photograph of a matte black supplement tub with a [your brand color] label, centered on a white infinity curve background. Soft directional lighting from the upper left. The label text reads [Your Product Name]. Subtle shadow beneath the tub. Studio product photography style. Shot on a Canon EOS R5, 85mm lens, f/2.8, sharp focus on the label. 4K resolution, clean and commercial.

PROMPT 2: Dark Moody Gym Environment (Instagram / Ad Creative)

Photorealistic product photograph of a matte black supplement tub with a [your brand color] label, placed on a raw concrete surface in a dimly lit industrial gym. Dramatic side-lighting from the right casting a long shadow. Blurred iron plates and a barbell rack in the background. Cinematic color grading with desaturated tones. Shot on a Sony A7 IV, 50mm lens, f/1.8, shallow depth of field. 4K resolution, editorial fitness photography.

PROMPT 3: Lifestyle Kitchen Counter (Wellness / Casual Audience)

Photorealistic product photograph of a white supplement tub with a [your brand color] label on a light marble kitchen counter. Warm natural window light from the left. A glass of water with ice and a small wooden cutting board with citrus slices sit beside the tub. Bright, airy, lifestyle wellness photography. Shot on a Nikon Z6 III, 35mm lens, f/4, everything in focus. 4K resolution, clean and aspirational.

Run each prompt in your preferred AI image tool. Generate three to five variations per prompt and select the best. These prompts are reusable: swap the product description for any future SKU and generate a matching content set in minutes.

Creating a Mockup Content Library

Before you launch, you need a minimum of five image types. Each serves a specific function across your store and marketing channels.

Image Type	Purpose	Where It Goes
Hero Product Shot (white background)	Primary product image. Clean, professional, conversion-focused.	Shopify product page (first image), Amazon listing, sell sheets
Lifestyle / Scene Shot	Shows the product in context. Builds aspiration and identity.	Instagram feed, Facebook ads, TikTok thumbnails, Shopify homepage
Ingredient / Texture Close-Up	Highlights the powder, scoop, or raw ingredients. Builds trust.	Product page gallery, Instagram carousel, A+ Content
Size Comparison Shot	Shows the tub next to a familiar object (shaker bottle, hand) for scale.	Product page gallery, Amazon secondary images
Multi-Flavor Lineup	Displays the full product line. Signals a real brand, not a one-SKU operation.	Shopify collection page, social banners, wholesale sell sheet

From Mockup to Marketing Asset

A high-resolution mockup is useless if it's the wrong size for the platform. Export every image at the native dimensions each channel requires.

Platform	Image Dimensions	Format	Notes
Shopify Product Page	2048 × 2048 px (square)	PNG or JPEG, <20MB	White or transparent background for hero. Shopify auto-crops; square ensures consistency.
Instagram Feed	1080 × 1080 px (square)	JPEG	Lifestyle shots outperform studio shots in feed. Save studio for the store.
TikTok Thumbnail	1080 × 1920 px (9:16 vertical)	JPEG or PNG	Bold product placement in center. Text overlay in top and bottom thirds.
Amazon A+ Content	970 × 600 px (landscape)	JPEG, <2MB, RGB	Amazon uses RGB, not CMYK. Re-export from your source file in sRGB color space.

Create a folder structure with subfolders for each platform. Export every mockup in all required sizes at once so you're never resizing on deadline.

What to do now:

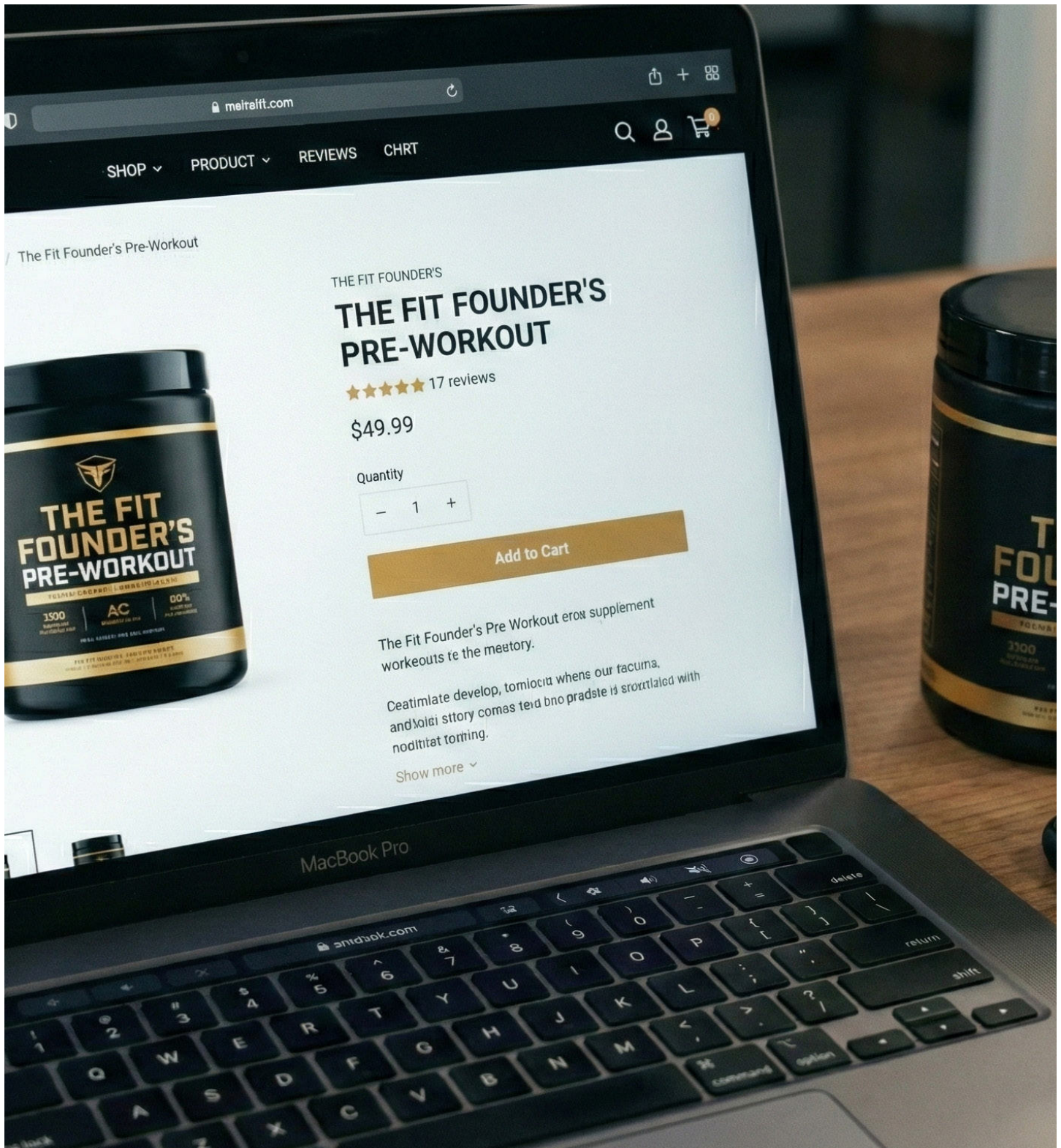
1. **Generate your hero product shot this week.** Use Prompt 1 (Clean Studio Shot) or a Photoshop smart-object template. This is your Shopify product page lead image and the single most important visual asset for your launch.
2. **Run all three AI prompts and build your five-image minimum.** Hero shot, lifestyle scene, ingredient close-up, size comparison, and multi-flavor lineup (even if you only have one flavor, mock up two or three to show the line's potential).
3. **Export every image at platform-native dimensions.** Use the export table above. Create a folder for each platform: Shopify, Instagram, TikTok, Amazon. Export once, use everywhere.
4. **Populate your Shopify product page before the product ships.** Upload your hero shot and gallery images. Write your product description using the benefit-first copy from Chapter 5. Your store should be live and collecting email signups before inventory arrives.
5. **Save your prompts for future SKUs.** When you launch your second product, swap the description in each prompt and generate a matching content library in under an hour. Consistency across your line signals a real brand.

Next: Chapter 12 — Selling at Volume: E-Commerce Infrastructure & Digital Marketing for CPG

CHAPTER 12

Selling at Volume

E-Commerce Infrastructure & Digital Marketing for CPG



Shopify Architecture for Premium CPG

You do not need a custom-built website. You need a Shopify store built like a premium supplement brand, not a dropshipping experiment. The difference is architecture: which theme you choose, how your product page is structured, and which apps handle the revenue mechanics.

Theme selection. Dawn (free) is clean and fast enough for launch. Prestige or Impulse (\$350 each) offer built-in features like image hotspots, ingredient sections, and countdown timers that premium CPG brands rely on. If your budget allows, start with Prestige. If not, Dawn with the right apps gets you 80% of the way there.

Product page architecture. Your product page should follow this section order, top to bottom: hero image with product name and benefit headline, subscription vs. one-time purchase toggle, social proof bar (review count and star rating), ingredient deep-dive with expandable panels, comparison table (your product vs. competitors), FAQ section, and a sticky add-to-cart bar that follows the scroll.

Three essential apps. ReCharge (\$99/month) for subscription management. Subscriptions increase lifetime value by 3–5x over one-time purchases. Judge.me (\$15/month) for verified reviews with photo uploads. Klaviyo (\$20+/month) for email and SMS flows. These three apps handle 90% of the revenue infrastructure a supplement brand needs at launch.

Conversion Rate Optimization for Supplement Pages

The average Shopify store converts at 1.4%. A well-built supplement product page converts at 3–4%. The difference between those numbers, at \$2,000/month in ad spend, is the difference between losing money and building a business.

A founder drove 8,000 visitors to his product page in the first month using TikTok ads. The page had a single product image, a two-sentence description, and no reviews. Conversion rate: 0.8%. He burned \$2,400 in ad spend and made \$2,700 in revenue. After rebuilding the page with the architecture below, his conversion rate hit 3.2% on the same traffic source. Same product, same ads, different page.

Above the fold: Hero mockup image (Chapter 11), product name as the largest text, hero benefit headline (Chapter 5), star rating with review count, and the price with a subscription option showing savings (“\$34.99 one-time / \$29.99/month with Subscribe & Save”). All of this must be visible without scrolling on both desktop and mobile.

Below the fold: Trust badges (Third-Party Tested, cGMP, serving count), a transparent Supplement Facts image, an ingredient explanation section that translates clinical doses into benefits (the same benefit-first framework from Chapter 5), three to five customer reviews with photos, and an FAQ addressing shipping, taste, and return policy.

The Complete DTC Marketing Funnel

Stage	Channel / Tactic	Goal	Benchmark
Top of Funnel	TikTok UGC (organic + spark ads), Meta broad-interest video ads, influencer seeding	Awareness and first-click traffic	CPM: \$5–\$15. CPC: \$0.50–\$2.00
Mid Funnel	Retargeting ads (testimonials, before/after), Klaviyo email flows (welcome series, education sequence)	Build trust and intent with warm traffic	Email open rate: 40%+ (welcome). ROAS: 3–5x on retargeting.
Bottom of Funnel	Cart abandonment emails (3-email sequence), SMS flash offers, subscription upsell at checkout	Convert intent to purchase	Cart recovery rate: 8–15%. Subscription opt-in: 20–30%.

For a first launch with \$2,000 in ad budget, allocate roughly 60% to top-of-funnel (TikTok and Meta), 25% to mid-funnel retargeting, and 15% to bottom-of-funnel SMS and email tools. Target a blended customer acquisition cost (CAC) under \$25 and a first-purchase ROAS of 2x or better. Profitability comes from repeat purchases and subscriptions, not the first order.

Influencer and UGC Strategy

Target micro-influencers (10k–100k followers). They have higher engagement rates and lower costs than macro creators. A fitness micro-influencer with 30k followers will typically produce a 30–60 second UGC video for \$100–\$500 plus free product. That video becomes an ad creative you can run for months.

Send a content brief, not a script. Tell them: the product name, one key benefit to mention, the format (unboxing, morning routine, gym bag essentials), and the CTA (“link in bio” or a discount code). Let them deliver it in their own voice. Overscripted UGC looks fake and performs worse in ads.

Whitelisting and spark ads. Ask permission to run paid ads through the influencer’s account (whitelisting on Meta, spark ads on TikTok). Ads run from a real person’s account convert 2–3x better than ads from a brand account. Include whitelisting rights in your agreement upfront.

Scaling Beyond Shopify

Amazon FBA. Once your DTC channel is profitable, list on Amazon. Create an A+ Content page using your mockup library (Chapter 11). Start PPC with automatic campaigns at \$15–\$25/day and refine to exact-match keywords after 30 days of data. Amazon takes a 15% referral fee plus FBA fulfillment costs; price accordingly.

TikTok Shop. The fastest-growing supplement sales channel in 2025. List your product, connect with TikTok affiliates who earn commission on sales, and run shop ads that let buyers purchase without leaving the app. Start here if your target buyer is the Aesthetic Enthusiast or Wellness Casual.

Wholesale. Use the retail readiness framework from Chapter 9. Do not expand to wholesale until your DTC conversion rate is above 2.5% and you have at least three months of consistent sales data. Retailers want proof of velocity, not a pitch deck.

What to do now:

1. **Build your Shopify product page using the section architecture above.** Hero image, subscription toggle, social proof bar, ingredient deep-dive, comparison table, FAQ, sticky add-to-cart. Use your Chapter 11 mockups for all imagery.
2. **Install ReCharge, Judge.me, and Klaviyo.** Set up a welcome email series (3 emails), a cart abandonment flow (3 emails), and a post-purchase review request. These three automated flows will generate revenue while you sleep.

- 3. Allocate your first \$2,000 ad budget.** 60% top-of-funnel (TikTok spark ads and Meta video), 25% retargeting, 15% SMS/email tools. Target a blended CAC under \$25.
 - 4. Reach out to five micro-influencers this week.** Send free product plus \$100–\$300 for a UGC video. Include whitelisting rights in the agreement. Use the best-performing video as your primary ad creative.
 - 5. Plan your second channel.** Once DTC is profitable with 90+ days of sales data, expand to Amazon FBA or TikTok Shop based on where your buyer archetype (Chapter 2) discovers brands. Do not expand to wholesale until conversion and velocity data support it.
-

You now have everything you need to design, print, and sell a premium supplement.

Go build.

Conclusion

From Blueprint to Shelf



You started this book with a product idea and a budget. You now have a complete system. A validated product choice. A buyer you can describe in one sentence. A brand identity that holds together across every touchpoint. A label with the correct hierarchy, printed on the right substrate, with finishes that justify a premium price. An FDA-compliant Supplement Facts panel. And a marketing infrastructure ready to convert traffic into revenue the day inventory arrives.

That is not a small thing. Most supplement brands launch with a Canva label and a prayer. You are launching with a process.

What Matters Most

If you take nothing else from these 12 chapters, take these seven principles.

Pick one buyer and design everything for them. A label that tries to attract everyone attracts no one. Your positioning statement from Chapter 2 is the single most important sentence in your business.

Lead with the benefit, not the ingredient. Buyers pick up a tub because of what it does for them. The ingredient validates the purchase. The benefit triggers it.

Premium is not expensive. It is intentional. Soft-touch matte lamination and spot UV on your logo add \$0.20 to \$0.50 per label. On a \$39.99 tub, that is invisible in your COGS and massive in perceived value.

FDA compliance is not optional and not difficult. Six mandatory elements, correct bolding rules, no disease claims, a properly formatted disclaimer. Follow the checklist. Run the AI prompts. The rules are specific, not complicated.

Validate before you scale. A 500-unit white-label test that sells out in 60 days is worth more than a 5,000-unit custom run gathering dust. Start small, prove demand, invest.

Your print file is a professional document. CMYK color mode, outlined text, 0.125-inch bleed, PDF/X-4 export, finish specification sheet. Get this right once and every reorder is effortless.

Marketing starts before the product ships. Mockups, a live Shopify store, email capture, and influencer outreach should all be running while your tubs are on the-

production line. Waiting for inventory before you start selling is the most expensive mistake in DTC.

Your Next Steps

1. **Write your positioning statement and pick your product.** Chapters 1 and 2. Everything else flows from these two decisions. Do not skip them.
2. **Lock your brand identity and sketch your label wireframe.** Chapters 3, 4, and 5. Colors, fonts, voice, finish specs, and the five-zone PDP hierarchy on paper before you touch design software.
3. **Build your Supplement Facts panel and run the three AI compliance prompts.** Chapters 6 and 7. A clean audit is your go/no-go gate for everything that follows.
4. **Contact three printers and three CMs using the email scripts.** Chapter 10. Send all six emails this week. Multiple quotes give you comparison data and negotiating power.
5. **Generate mockups and launch your Shopify store before inventory arrives.** Chapters 11 and 12. Your store should be collecting emails and running ads while your product is still in production.

The Label Design Template Kit, the FDA Compliance Toolkit, and the Retail-Ready Sell Sheet Pack are available separately and pick up exactly where this ebook leaves off, giving you the ready-made files and templates referenced throughout these chapters.

The supplement industry does not reward the best formula. It rewards the brand that looks professional, earns trust at first glance, and gets to market before the moment passes. You now have the blueprint to be that brand. The only difference between reading this book and building a business from it is a production run, a Shopify store, and the decision to start. Go build.

If You Made it Here!

Congratulations! You should now have a greater understanding of the process behind building a supplement brand that looks good and speaks directly to your audience.

I would like to reward your diligence for making it this far by offering you a **FREE 30-Minute Consultation** to discuss your brand and provide feedback and insight.

Write to me on WhatsApp! I will sit with you and take a look at where you are at in your process, provide feedback and bounce ideas to maximize on your investment.

Write to **786-848-1522** and I will schedule you in!